
ACTOR PART BOOK

The Step-Daughter

the one who refuses to let it be made beautiful

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore · Pirandello, trans. Storer 1922

A Village Players production · Lausanne

Director: **Kiarash Jamshidi**

117 SPEECHES · 2974 WORDS ACROSS THE PLAY

WHO THE STEP-DAUGHTER IS

She is the moral centre of the play. Not the Father with his philosophy, not the Manager with his stagecraft — her. Her anger is precise: she is in a room of theatre people who would like to turn what happened to her into *a scene, a moment, a confession* — anything but what it is. She refuses. Every line of hers is some version of *stop making this beautiful. Stop making this clever. Stop making this safe. This happened. Look at it.* She is dressed in elegant mourning and she knows how to use a room; the seduction the old text gestures at is not flirtation but exposure — a weapon turned outward because everything else has been taken from her. Play her sharp, in control, never apologetic, never coquettish. The wit is real but the wit is rage. Her café-concert turn — she sings and dances *Valentine* — belongs to this and is not a break from it: it is a provocation from a wound, a girl the room has just heard is two months orphaned and lately for sale daring them to enjoy her body in song. Earn the laugh, then let it curdle in the same breath; if it plays as a merely funny number, the danger underneath it has been lost. Her tenderness for the Child-bundle must be unbearably real, so that her contempt for the Boy-chair reads as the same wound, pointed the other way. She has a single sustained monologue at the start of Act Two, alone in the shower-light, where she speaks to her silent siblings as real children: tender to the Child-bundle in her arms, then violent with the Boy-chair when she takes the revolver from its pocket. It is the production's most exposed solo moment. The Father she neither pities nor forgives; she has not finished punishing him, and she will not be staged into doing so.

THE PLAY, AND HOW IT BEGINS

What it is. Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921). A theatre company's ordinary rehearsal is interrupted by six figures — a Father, a Mother, a Step-Daughter, a Son, and two silent children — who claim to be unfinished Characters, abandoned by their author, and demand that their drama be staged. The evening is the collision between their fixed, unbearable story and a working company's attempt to turn it into theatre.

This production. Set in Lausanne, played by **nine live performers** with **two stage objects** in place of the two youngest children (a coat-and-chair for the Boy, a wrapped bundle for the Child), on three stripped settings — **no projection, no screen.** One interval, after Act One; the second half plays unbroken to the fountain.

How it opens. The curtain is already up on a half-lit working stage. The Village Players are dragging themselves into a rehearsal of another Pirandello play, *Mixing It Up* — the Manager arrives tired and behind, there is the business of the cook's cap, the Players bicker. Then the working lights soften to a strange amber: the Door-keeper carries in the Boy-chair, and the four family Characters walk on, the Step-Daughter already holding the Child-bundle. From that entrance the play has begun, and it does not let go.

HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Everything this role says and does, in performance order, grouped by act and by part. Each speech is preceded by a short **CUE** — the tail of the line before it — so you can find your entrance. Where the role doubles a function, the function is printed beside the line (*as Prompter*, and so on); chorus lines the company speaks together keep their group tag (*All Three Players*). Blocking lives in the bracketed action cues inside the speeches. The text is pulled byte-for-byte from the Director's Copy, so it always matches the current script.

Act One — The Family

PART I *The Rehearsal*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

The white working lights soften into a warm amber — the "tenuous light" Pirandello specifies for the Six. The DOOR-KEEPER enters from the stage door carrying the BOY-CHAIR — the black coat over its back, the cap on its seat, the satchel by its leg — sets it at the edge of the stage, and advances towards the Manager's table, taking off his braided cap. During this manoeuvre, the four live CHARACTERS — FATHER, MOTHER, STEP-DAUGHTER, SON — enter, and stop by the door at back of stage. The STEP-DAUGHTER is already carrying the CHILD-BUNDLE.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER is dashing, almost impudent, beautiful. She wears mourning too, but with great elegance. She shows contempt for the wretched Boy-chair at the edge of the stage; she shows a lively tenderness for the Child-bundle in her arms.

PART II *The Arrival*

7 SPEECHES · 125 WORDS

CUE *The Manager:* But there's no author here. We are not rehearsing a new piece.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[stepping in front of the Father, taking the line].* So much the better, sir, so much the better. You can put us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.

CUE *The Father:* ... Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We may be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us.

CUE *The Father:* ... lie about themselves the way we can. I agree with you entirely.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[quiet, just to the room].* Truer. He has been using that word for years. Ask my mother how true it sounded.

CUE *The Father:* ... because there is no "book" which contains us, you refuse to believe...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[advances towards MANAGER, eyes level, not smiling].* Believe me, we are really six most interesting characters, sir — left stranded halfway.

CUE *The Father:* ... were born too — but left without a world to hold us.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, to no one in particular].* He has said all this to himself before. Many times.

CUE *The Father:* ... impatient to play it. Our inner passion drives us on to this.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[without looking at him].* His passion. Always the word *passion*. *[crossing behind the Father, voice flat]* My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for *him*. *[Places a deliberate hand on the FATHER'S shoulder, leaves it there one beat too long, withdraws. A single short laugh — no warmth in it.]*

CUE *The Father:* Behave yourself! And please don't laugh in that fashion.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. With your permission, gentlemen, I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. *Don't worry — it isn't a hymn.* *[Sings and then dances Valentine — bright, knowing, the smile a fraction too wide. Not a cabaret turn for its own sake but a provocation thrown by someone two*

months orphaned and lately for sale, daring the room to enjoy her. The audience should laugh, and then, a beat later, wish they had not.]

PART III *The Veil*

11 SPEECHES · 398 WORDS

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to Manager]*. Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this little darling, and this fool here *[Seizing the coat off the chair and shaking it.]* does the stupidest thing — you will see me run away. Yes, gentlemen, I'll be off. But the moment hasn't come yet. After what has taken place between him and me *[Indicating the Father with a horrible wink.]*, I can't stay here, watching her anguish over that fool *[Indicates the Son.]*. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the *legitimate* son. He despises us all because we are bastards. *[Goes to the Mother and embraces her.]* And he won't even recognise her as his mother. *Wretch.*

| **CUE** *The Mother*: No! No!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

| **CUE** *The Mother*: ... him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true.

| **CUE** *The Mother*: Not true? And what can you know about it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true. Don't believe it. *[To MANAGER.]* Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. *[Indicates the SON.]* She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because this man *[Indicates the FATHER.]* forced her to it.

| **CUE** *The Mother*: ... speak. You are not in a position to know anything about it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

| **CUE** *The Mother*: No, I don't deny it...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He was always full of affection and kindness for you. *[Turning on the Boy-chair, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him by it.]* It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

| **CUE** *The Father*: ... word — some simple word that means nothing, and yet calms us?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Even remorse. Especially remorse.

| **CUE** *The Father*: ... No. It took more than words to quiet the remorse in me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, there was money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — and I two months an orphan. *[A ripple of unease among the ACTORS.]*

| **CUE** *The Son*: This is vile.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace's shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those *ladies* who take in poor girls of good family on the pretext of selling *robes et manteaux*. The pretext is always *robes*. The arrangement is always something else.

CUE *The Son*: ... — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It was a near thing, though, you know! [*the laugh she means to be ironic does not quite come*]

CUE *The Mother*: Shame, my daughter. Not in front of her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the *revenge*. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, a screen, and in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I see it. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, might look elsewhere for this part of it. I do not blush, however. *He* does. [*Indicating FATHER.*]

PART IV *His Version*

19 SPEECHES · 472 WORDS

CUE *The Father*: ... what she has just put on me, you must let me explain.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

CUE *The Father*: ... She has a heart for the children. When I speak — nothing.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us.

CUE *The Father*: ... her. Kindred souls — without the slightest suspicion of evil between them.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. So he thought of it — for them!

CUE *The Father*: ... up healthy and strong — his mother did not seem strong enough.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*pointing at him, no smile*]. As one can see.

CUE *The Manager*: Yes, please stop it, for Heaven's sake.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But imagine moral sanity from *him*, if you please — a regular customer of Madame Pace's shop. A very regular customer.

CUE *The Father*: ... she inspired in me — for the pity I felt for her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*flat, into the room*]. He calls it pity. He was caught buying his stepdaughter in the back of a dressmaker's shop. He calls it *pity*.

CUE *The Father*: ... long way off — the new family that grew up around her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*the cleverness drops — just the child she was*]. Oh yes, that's true enough. When I was little, so high, you know, with plaits over my shoulders and my skirt down past my knees, I used to see him waiting outside the school for me to come out. He came, sir, to see how I was *growing up*.

CUE *The Father*: This is infamous, shameful!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No. Why?

CUE *Player 2*: Should we be writing this down? Some of it sounds important.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, yes. True. He used to follow me in the street. I told my mother, who guessed at once. [*The Mother agrees with a nod.*] She wouldn't send me to school for some days. When I went back, there he was again, with a paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers. For me.

CUE *The Father*: ... see, is no longer the schoolgirl with plaits down her back —.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. — and the skirt down past the knee!

CUE *The Father*: The drama is coming now, sir; something new, complex, most interesting.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. As soon as my father died...

CUE *The Father*: ... was ever there at all. That is the only difference between us.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. All appear to have the courage to do them though.

CUE *The Father*: ... is the way we tell each other: blind yourself, because I have.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Sometimes one of the two cannot look away any more — when she no longer feels the need of hiding her shame from herself, but dry-eyed and dispassionately sees only the shame of the man who has blinded himself without love. Oh, all this philosophy that uncovers the worst in a man and then seeks to excuse him — I can't stand it, sir. When a man simplifies life down to appetite, throwing aside every finer aspiration, every sense of duty, modesty, shame — then nothing is more revolting than the remorse that follows. Crocodile's tears, that's what it is.

CUE *The Father*: ... as a seamstress — in the shop of a certain Madame Pace.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. A real high-class modiste, gentlemen. In appearance she dresses the leaders of the best society — but she arranges matters so those elegant ladies serve her purpose, and the rest of us — well, the rest of us serve a rather different purpose.

CUE *The Mother*: ... hag offered me work because she had her eye on my daughter.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Poor Mother! Do you know, sir, what that woman did when I brought her back the work my mother had finished? She would point out to me that I had torn one of my dresses, and she would give it back to my mother to mend. It was I who paid for it, always I; while this poor creature here believed she was sacrificing herself for me and these two children here, sitting up at night sewing Madame Pace's dresses.

CUE *The Manager*: And one day you met there...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Him, him. Yes sir, an old client. There's a scene for you to play! Superb!

CUE *The Father*: She, the Mother arrived just then...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Almost in time.

CUE *The Father*: ... you see her, and I who cannot look her in the face.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Absurd! How can I possibly be expected — after *that* — to play the modest young miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of "a solid moral sanity"?

CUE *The Father*: ... me forever to that one room, that one table, that one envelope.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*flat*]. You walked into that room by yourself.

PART V *The Son*

3 SPEECHES · 126 WORDS

CUE *The Son*: ... to be mixed up in all this with the rest of you.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We are vulgar folk, sir. *He* is the fine gentleman. You may have noticed, Mr. Manager, that I fix him now and again with a look that makes him lower his eyes — because he knows what he did to me.

CUE *The Son*: I?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. You — *you*! I owe my life on the streets to you. Did you, or did you not, deny us — I won't say the warmth of home, but even the bare hospitality that makes a guest feel at ease? We were intruders,

come to disturb the kingdom of your *legitimacy*. It was *his* behaviour that made me insist on the reason I had come — with my mother, who is his mother too. *And I came as mistress of the house.*

CUE *The Father:* ... doesn't recognise you but knows you are her son... See, she's crying!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*without looking at the MOTHER*]. Like a fool.

PART VI *The Bargain*

2 SPEECHES · 19 WORDS

CUE *The Manager:* ... in what you say. I don't like it, but it interests me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*coming forward*]. When you've got a character like me.

CUE *The Manager:* ... first scene. Come to my office. We'll see what can be done.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*level*]. Extraordinary, yes — if he does not get to tell it alone.

Act Two — The Theatre

PART I *The Setup*

13 SPEECHES · 280 WORDS

THE STEP-DAUGHTER comes out of the MANAGER's office carrying the Child-bundle and dragging the Boy-chair behind her. As she comes out of the office, she cries: —

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! nonsense! Do it yourselves! I'm not going to mix myself up in this mess. *[Turning to the Child-bundle in her arms and coming quickly onto the stage.]* Come on, Rosetta, let's run! *[She drags the Boy-chair to a spot a little behind her and leaves it there, leaning.]*

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... to mix myself up in this mess. Come on, Rosetta, let's run!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[bends over the Child-bundle and takes the cloth between her hands as if it were a small face].* My little darling! You're frightened, aren't you? You don't know where we are. *[Pretending to reply to the Child.]* Don't be afraid, Rosetta. It's only a stage — a place where they make false things and call them true. A fountain — just suppose it, here, in the middle. All make-believe, my pet; and better so, for a real one would only frighten you. *[A pang.]* You who are real, baby dear — who really played by a real fountain, green and beautiful, with the little ducks. *[She sets the Child-bundle down carefully and reaches for the coat on the Boy-chair, taking it by the sleeve as if by the boy's arm.]* And you — what have you got there? *[She slides her hand into the coat pocket and finds the revolver, holds it up briefly in the column of light, then returns it to the pocket.]* Ah. Where did you get this? Idiot. If I had been in your place — instead of killing myself, I'd have shot one of those two. Or both. Father and son.

The piano dies on her last word. The shower holds on her for one more breath, then releases. The working lights come up. The Step-Daughter is alone on the upper platform with the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair. The Boy and the Child are silent objects again.

CUE *The Manager:* ... are one or two points to settle still. Will you come along?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[following him towards the office].* Ouff! what's the good, if you've arranged everything. *[The FATHER, MANAGER and STEP-DAUGHTER go back into the office again (off) for a moment. At the same time, THE SON followed by THE MOTHER, comes out.]*

CUE *Player 2:* There's the green one. It is the sofa we have.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No no! Green won't do. It was yellow, ornamented with flowers — very large! and most comfortable!

CUE *The Manager:* It doesn't matter. Use the one we've got.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Doesn't matter? It's most important!

CUE *The Manager:* ... interfere. See if we've got a shop window — long and narrowish.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the little table! The little mahogany table for the pale blue envelope!

CUE *The Manager:* That'll do fine.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the screen! There must be a screen. Otherwise how am I to *manage*?

CUE *The Manager*: We want some clothes pegs too, don't we?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[she knows the geography of that room — knows where Madame Pace kept everything]*. Yes. Several. There were always several. On the wall by the screen.

CUE *The Manager*: ... in this way: You are the Son. You naturally are the Step-Daughter...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[a single hard laugh, head turning]*. What? *What?* I — that woman there?

CUE *Player 2*: ... Nobody. I insist on being treated with respect — otherwise I go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, no, excuse me... I'm not laughing at you...

CUE *Player 2*: "That woman there"...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But I wasn't speaking of *you*, you know. I was speaking of myself — whom I can't see in you at all. I don't know quite how to put it — but no, you really aren't anything like me.

CUE *The Manager*: ... lose any more time! Is it all right as it is now?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well, to tell the truth, I don't recognize the scene.

CUE *The Manager*: ... No, no, you must wait. I meant her You just watch —

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[adding at once]*. How I'll play it, how I'll live it!...

PART II *The Apparition*

20 SPEECHES · 382 WORDS

The door at the back of stage opens and MADAME PACE enters and takes a few steps forward. She is a fat, oldish woman with puffy oxygenated hair, rouged and powdered, dressed with a comical elegance in black silk. Round her waist is a long silver chain from which hangs a pair of scissors. The audience should read her at first as absurd — an apparition out of a comic operetta, conjured from the costume department of every small shop in Lausanne that has ever overcharged a foreigner. She has come, however, from somewhere real: a back room off the rue de Bourg, where the accounts book lies open on a desk and a customer is waiting. The comedy is her front. The scissors at her waist are not. The STEP-DAUGHTER runs over to her at once amid the stupor of the actors.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[turning towards her]*. There she is! There she is!

CUE *Player 3*: Louder! Louder please!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[leaving MADAME PACE, who smiles a Sphinx-like smile, and advancing towards the actors]*. Louder? Louder? What on earth are you talking about? These aren't matters one shouts at the top of one's voice. If I spoke them loud, sir, it was to *shame* him and have my revenge. *[Indicates FATHER.]* But for Madame it's quite a different matter.

The STEP-DAUGHTER, level and unhurried, makes a sign of disagreement two or three times with her finger.

CUE *The Manager*: What do you mean by no?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, no theatrics]*. There's someone who will hear us if she *[Indicating MADAME PACE.]* speaks out loud.

CUE *The Manager*: ... We must observe the conventions of the theatre. Before you are ready...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[interrupting him]*. No, get on with it at once! I'm just dying, I tell you, to act this scene. If he's ready, I'm more than ready.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... must have the scene between you and this lady... Do you understand?...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Good Heavens! She's been telling me what you know already: that my mother's work is badly done again, that the material's ruined; and that if I want her to continue to help us in our misery I must be patient...

| **CUE** *The Manager*: What? What? She talks like that?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[also laughing]*. Yes yes, that's the way she talks — that accent of hers! Most comical it is!

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... to lift all this gloom. Of course she talks like that! Magnificent!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Magnificent? Certainly! When such things are said to a girl in language of that kind, the effect is certain, since it seems almost a joke. One feels inclined to laugh when one hears her recite her inventory of clients — clean ones, polite ones, paying ones — as if she were counting bolts of silk. Nice old gentleman, eh, Madame?

| **CUE** *The Mother*: ... May God forgive me. May God forgive me. I drank the tea.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[running over to calm her MOTHER — and a little frightened, perhaps, by the voice she has just heard come out of her]*. Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

| **CUE** *The Mother*: Well then. Take that woman out of my sight.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to MANAGER]*. It is impossible for my mother to remain here.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Come on, Madame, come on!

| **CUE** *Madame Pace*: ... rule of the house. House rule. Pace, she keep the house rules.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Bring on this *old gentleman* who wants to talk so nicely to me. *[Addressing the COMPANY imperiously.]* We've got to do this scene one way or another, haven't we? Come on! *[To MADAME PACE.]* You can go!

| **CUE** *Madame Pace*: ... always the debt. There is always Pace. Don't you forget the name.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to the FATHER]*. Now you make your entry. No, you needn't go over there. Come here. Let's suppose you've already come in. Like that, yes! I'm here with my head bowed, modest-like. Come on! Out with your voice! Say "Good afternoon, Miss" in that peculiar tone, that special tone...

| **CUE** *The Father*: Good afternoon, Miss.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[head bowed down slightly, with restrained disgust]*. Good afternoon!

| **CUE** *The Father*: ... I say... this isn't the first time you've come here, is it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[the rehearsed bow — no softness in it]*. No sir.

| **CUE** *The Father*: ... to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[anticipating him and with veiled disgust]*. No sir... I'll do it myself. *[Takes it off quickly.]*

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... We're playing the scene now I'd have you notice. Begin again, please!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[continuing]*. No thank you, sir.

CUE *The Father*: ... then — Madame will be pleased. She expects it, anyway, you know.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, no! I couldn't wear it!

CUE *The Father*: ... dear girl, there's always a way round these little matters, you know.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[level, not pleading]*. No, it's not that. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. *[Touches the front of her black dress, once.]*

CUE *The Father*: ... mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm — I'm frightfully sorry...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[forcing herself to conquer her indignation and nausea]*. Stop! Stop! It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. *[Tries to smile.]* I must forget that I am dressed so...

CUE *The Manager*: ... arranged. Pretty good that scene, where he offers her the hat, eh?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. The best's coming now. Why can't we go on?

PART III *The Substitution*

23 SPEECHES · 578 WORDS

CUE *The Manager*: Good! You stay here with your head bowed down a bit.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But she isn't dressed in black.

The STEP-DAUGHTER noticing the way the LEADING MAN enters, bursts out laughing.

CUE *The Manager*: ... stop that laughing. If we go on like this, we'll never finish.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me, sir, but it's natural enough. This lady *[Indicating LEADING LADY.]* stands there still; but if she is supposed to be me, I can assure you that if I heard anyone say "Good afternoon" in that manner and in that tone, I would burst out laughing — exactly as I did.

CUE *The Manager*: ... no, stop! Let her nod "yes" first. "You've been here before, eh?"

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[unable to contain herself]*. Oh my God! *[Puts a hand to her mouth to prevent herself from laughing.]*

CUE *The Manager*: What's the matter?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nothing, nothing!

A short, theatrical pause. The FATHER turns his face away. The STEP-DAUGHTER is no longer struggling not to laugh — she is staring.

CUE *The Manager*: ... the back-and-forth on the mourning — straight through to the next beat.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, almost to herself]*. He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry."

CUE *The Manager*: We've done that bit. Move on.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

CUE *The Manager*: They will sit down.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[hard, decisive]*. We will not.

CUE *The Manager*: Silence! for once and all, I tell you!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me! forgive me!

CUE *The Manager*: ... it again; and try and see if you can't keep from laughing.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Oh, I shan't laugh any more. There's a nice little bit coming for me now: you'll see.

CUE *The Manager*: ... in sharp with "I understand, I understand"; and then you ask her...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[interrupting]*. What?

CUE *The Manager*: Why she is in mourning.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Not at all! See here, sir — when I told him it was useless for me to think about wearing mourning, do you know what he said? "Ah well," he said, "then let's take this little dress off."

CUE *The Manager*: Great! Just what we want, to make a riot in the theatre!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But it's the truth!

CUE *The Manager*: ... our business here. Truth up to a certain point, but no further.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. What do you want to do then?

CUE *The Manager*: You'll see, you'll see! Leave it to me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, sir. What you want is a little *romantic sentimental* scene pieced together out of my disgust — out of every cruel and vile reason I am what I am. He is to ask me why I wear mourning; I am to answer, with tears in my eyes, that it is just two months since papa died. No, sir. No. He has to say to me — as he did say, the way one speaks to a child — *well, let's take this little dress off*.

CUE *The Manager*: For Heaven's sake! What are you saying?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[no longer playing]*. The truth. The truth.

CUE *The Manager*: ... can't have this kind of thing on the stage. It won't go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Not possible, eh? Very well! I'm much obliged to you — but I'm off!

CUE *The Manager*: Now be reasonable! Don't lose your temper!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I won't stay here. I will not. I can see you've fixed it all up with him in your office. All this talk about what is *possible* on the stage — I understand. He wants his complicated head-drama. His guilt. His torments. All performed in good taste. But I want to act my part. *My part*.

CUE *The Manager*: ... my dear — this fury of yours may make a bad impression.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[head lowered, not yielding]*. It's true. But remember those others mean *him* for me all the same.

CUE *The Manager*: What? The others? What do you mean?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. For a woman who has gone wrong, sir, the man responsible for the first fault is responsible for everything that follows. He is responsible for *all* my faults — was responsible, before I was even born. Look at him, sir. See if it isn't true.

CUE *The Manager*: ... you? Give him a chance to act it, to get it over!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. How? How can he act his *noble guilt*, his *moral suffering*, if you want to spare him the horror of being discovered one day — after he had asked her what he asked her — in the arms of her, that already fallen woman, that *child*, sir — the child he used to watch come out of school? *[She is moved.] [The MOTHER at this point is overcome with emotion, and breaks out into a fit of crying. All are touched. A long pause.]*

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... sir — the child he used to watch come out of school?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[as soon as the MOTHER becomes a little quieter, adds resolutely and gravely]*. At present, we are unknown to the public. Tomorrow, you will act us as you wish, treating us in your own manner. But do you really want to see drama, do you want to see it flash out as it really did?

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... want, so I can use as much of it as is possible.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well then, ask that Mother there to leave us.

| **CUE** *The Father*: ... passion in all of us that must culminate in her final cry.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I can hear it still in my ears. It has driven me mad, that cry. You may put me on as you like — fully dressed, if you like — provided I have at least my arm bare. Because, standing like this *[She leans her head on the Father's breast.]*, with my head so and my arms round his neck, I saw a vein pulsing in my arm here; and then, as if that live vein had awakened disgust in me, I closed my eyes like this, and let my head sink against his breast. *[Turning to the Mother.]* Cry out, mother. *Cry out as you did then!*

Act Three — The Question

PART I *The Trap*

9 SPEECHES · 176 WORDS

CUE *The Manager:* ... all to me as we arranged, and you'll see! It'll go fine!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Our entry into his house [*Indicates FATHER.*] in spite of him... [*Indicates the SON.*]

CUE *The Manager:* Leave it to me, I tell you!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Do let it be clear, at any rate, that it is in spite of my wishes.

CUE *The Mother:* For all the good that's come of it...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*turning towards her quickly*]. It doesn't matter. The more harm done us, the more remorse for him.

CUE *The Mother:* ... quite plain that for conscience' sake I did try in every way...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*interrupting indignantly and continuing for the MOTHER*]... to pacify me, to dissuade me from spiting him. [*To MANAGER.*] Do as she wants: satisfy her, because it's true! I enjoy it immensely. Any how, as you can see, the meeker she is, the more she tries to get at his heart, the more distant and aloof does he become.

CUE *The Manager:* Are we going to begin this second act or not?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I'm not going to talk any more now. But I must tell you this: you can't have the whole action take place at the fountain, as you suggest. It isn't possible!

CUE *The Manager:* Why not?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Because he [*Indicates the SON again.*] is always shut up alone in his room. And then there's all the part of that poor dazed-looking boy there which takes place indoors.

CUE *Player 2:* Is this still the play, or has it become something else?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*level, never raising her voice — colder than the philosophy*]. His *reality*. He always knew exactly where to find me.

CUE *The Father:* But of course. Without doubt.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*the same temperature; addressing the room, not him*]. He was real that afternoon. With his hundred francs. He was very real.

CUE *The Manager:* ... it can change. It is always changing, the same as anyone else's.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*before the Father can answer — flat, precise*]. His doesn't change. Mine doesn't either. He should know.

PART II *The Refusal*

9 SPEECHES · 403 WORDS

CUE *The Father:* ... that he can be imagined in scenes the author never dreamed of.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*quiet*]. Listen to him. Even now he is the author.

CUE *Player 3:* ... I keep waiting for one of you to say that we should.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I tempted him too — many times. He would sit at his writing-table at twilight, too tired to turn on the lamp, and the shadows would fill with us, come to tempt him. *[As if she saw herself still there.]* Let us live, I would whisper — the mother with her son, I with the little ones, and then I alone in the dark, offering him scene after scene. *[A sudden movement, as if she would seize the vision.]* Ah! my life! my life! And he turned away from all of it.

CUE *The Father:* ... refused to give us life: because you were too insistent, too troublesome.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Didn't he make me so himself? *[Goes close to the MANAGER to tell him, as if in confidence.]* In my opinion he abandoned us in a fit of depression, of disgust for the ordinary theatre as the public knows it and likes it.

CUE *The Manager:* ... For Heaven's sake, man, let's get along and come to the scene.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It seems to me we've got too much action with our coming into his house. *[Indicating FATHER.]* You said, before, you couldn't change the scene every five minutes.

CUE *The Manager:* ... a project which — what did you say it did to him?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Consumes him, sir. Wastes him away. He has not eaten properly since we came into that house.

CUE *The Manager:* ... the house, and the other out at the fountain: isn't that it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, in the sun, in the sun! That is my only pleasure — to see her happy and careless by the fountain, after the misery and squalor of the horrible room where we all four slept together. And I had to sleep beside her — I, do you understand? — carrying everything I carried, next to her, with her folding me in her loving little arms. By the fountain, whenever she spied me, she would run to take me by the hand. She loved the little flowers, and would show them to me.

CUE *The Manager:* ... like that. Show your head a little, as if looking for someone.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It's useless to hope he will speak, as long as that fellow there is here... *[Indicates the SON.]* You must send him away first.

CUE *The Manager:* ... do you mean by saying you've got nothing to do with this?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[calmly — she knows him].* Don't bother to stop him. He won't go.

CUE *The Son:* ... at all. I've said so from the very beginning. Let me go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[going over to the Manager].* Allow me? *[Puts down the Manager's arm.]* Well, go on then — go away. *[The Son looks at her with contempt and hatred. She laughs.]* You see? He *can't*. He is obliged to stay here, *indissolubly bound to the chain*. If I, who fly off when what has to happen happens, because I cannot bear him — if I am still here, enduring that face of his — you can well imagine he is unable to move. He has to remain. With that nice father of his, and that mother whose firstborn he is. *[To the Mother.]* Come on, mother, come along! *[To Manager.]* You see? She was getting up to keep him back — she, who dreads showing your actors anything of what she feels. That is how badly she wants to be near him. She is willing to act her part.

PART III *The Fountain*

1 SPEECH · 15 WORDS

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Wait a minute, wait... First of all, the baby has to go to the fountain... *[Lifts the Child-bundle from the Mother's lap and carries it to the fountain.]*

